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INTERNATIONAL UNIVERSITY



RIPHAH
DEPARTMENT OF ISLAMIC STUDIES

The Islam and Political Ethics

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Objectives of the lecture

- To know how Islam politically organizes humans to establish a just and equitable political system.
- To know how much is Islam a democratic religion.
- To know the Islamic point of view about secularism
- To know the Islamic point of view about socialism
- To know about kingship and the difference between kingship and Khilafah.



Basic Questions...

- What is the importance of politics in Islam?
- What are different viewpoints of Muslim scholars about the Western Political System of democracy?
- What is the status of secularism, socialism and monarchy in Islam?



Political System of Islam

The political system of Islam is based on two basic realities:

- (a) The personal position of Allah vis-à-vis this universe, particularly men. He is not only their Creator and Supporter but also their real Master.

Allah says in the Quran; "أَلَا لَهُ الْخَلْقُ وَالْأَمْرُ"

Lo! To Him alone belong the creation and the command. (*Al-A'raf*, 7:54)

The sense is that it is Allah alone who creates and rules all the material and abstract things of the entire universe.

- (b) The personal position of man. He is not only created and supported by Allah (the Supporter of all the worlds) but is also His humble slave and His vicegerent in this world.

Islam at a Glance, page: 114.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a12>



Salient features of Islamic political system

1. The supreme authority and sovereignty actually rest with Allah alone. No individual, clan, community or even the whole mankind has an iota of share in it. Man is by birth His slave.

﴿إِنِ الْحُكْمُ إِلَّا لِلَّهِ أَمَرَ أَلَّا تَعْبُدُوا إِلَّا إِيَّاهُ ذَلِكَ الدِّينُ الْقَيِّمُ وَلَكِنَّ أَكْثَرَ النَّاسِ لَا يَعْلَمُونَ﴾ سورة يوسف: 40

“Sovereignty belongs to none but Allah. He has ordained that you shall not worship anyone but Him. This is the only right path.” (12 : 40).

2. Allah alone is the real Legislator. The constitution given by Him is the constitution of man's life. It alone governs the life of man. No individual or institution has the power to make one for himself or others.

Islam at a Glance, page: 114.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a>



Salient features of Islamic political system

3. The Prophet of Allah (peace be upon him) is the representative and the expounder of His injunctions and pleasures. By virtue of this position, he acquires the status of a subordinate legislator and therefore his orders call for the same obedience that is due to the original legislator.

Allah says in the Quran;

وَمَا آتَاكُمُ الرَّسُولُ فَخُذُوهُ وَمَا نَهَاكُمْ عَنْهُ فَانْتَهُوا

And whatever the messenger gives you, take it, and whatever he forbids you from, abstain from it. (*Al-Hashr*, 59:7)

The obedience of the Messenger is nothing but the obedience of Allah:

"whoever obeys the Messenger obeys Allah" (4 : 80).

Islam at a Glance, page: 115.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a>



Salient features of Islamic political system

4. For the exact implementation of the Divine injunctions, the setting up of a collective system and a governing institution is but indispensable.

In technical terms it is known as "Khilafat" or "Imamat" or "Amarat". This institution is comprised of one man who is called "the Khalifah" or "the Imam" or "the Amir".

5. Everyone who professes faith in Islam is a citizen of the Islamic State. This provision not only includes such Muslims who are born in that state but every Muslim, to whatever country he belongs, becomes its citizen when he enters it. "And the believers, men and women are protecting friends one of another"(9: 71).

Islam at a Glance, page: 115.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a>



Salient features of Islamic political system

6. There is a council of advisors to assist the Khalifah in his heavy responsibilities. It is incumbent on him to run the affairs of the state in accordance with their advice.

Allah says in the Quran;

وَشَاوِرْهُمْ فِي الْأَمْرِ

"And consult with them upon the conduct of affairs" (3 : 159)

وَأْمُرْهُمْ شُورَى بَيْنَهُمْ

And whose affairs are settled with mutual consultation between them. (42: 38)

Islam at a Glance, page: 115.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a>



Salient features of Islamic political system

7. Islam has not specified any method for the election of the Khalifah. Rather, gave us a very basic principle and guidance to elect the Khalifah. Any system of election which is consonant with these two requirements, the purpose and the guiding principle for election, would be an Islamic System.
- The purpose is that such a person is elected who is better than the others in knowledge, fear of Allah, sagacity, talents and practical capabilities and who commands the respect of the people and is trusted by them.
 - The guiding principle is that he is elected by such persons who hold a distinguished position by virtue of their intelligence, love of religion and power of decision. The public at large concurs their decision.

Islam at a Glance, page: 115.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a>



Salient features of Islamic political system

8. The office of the Khilafat, or for that matter any office of the government, cannot be given to a person who himself desires or demands it.

The Prophet Muhammad ﷺ said:

"By Allah, we will not confer the office upon one who demands it or is covetous about it" (*Sahi Bukhari: 7149*).

This is so because the Islamic concept of government is different from the ordinary. It is a responsibility and security rather than a right, and one would be answerable to Allah for it.

9. It is the bounden duty of every citizen to obey the orders of the Khalifah: "Obey Allah and obey the Messenger and those of you who are in authority" (4 : 59).

Islam at a Glance, page: 117.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a>



Salient features of Islamic political system

10. The Islamic State is responsible for the life, property and honor of every citizen regardless of his religion.

Similarly, every citizen is free to practice his religion and enjoys complete freedom of conscience.

This freedom is, however, subject to the restriction that no one is allowed to incite people to revolt against the State.

Nor has anyone the liberty to say things which lead to disruption and disorder in the society or cause a moral decline.

No one is to be deprived of his freedom without a proper trial of the charge levelled against him.

Islam at a Glance, page: 118.

<https://www.islamicstudies.info/literature/glance.htm#a>



Islam & Democracy

Democracy meaning and understanding:

Literally means rule or government by people.

Democratic system includes voting and respect for election results, but it also requires protection of rights and freedoms, respect for legal and constitutional rights. It is a political system in which people choose their authoritative leaders freely from among competing groups and individuals. Democracy is a political system in which different groups are legally entitled to compete for power and in which institutional power holders are elected by the people and are answerable to the people.*

*(Journal of Democracy Vol. 1, 1990)



Link of Democracy with Capitalism

- Democracy is the political ideology of capitalism.
- Democracy and Capitalism co-exist in many variations.
- Capitalism needs free market economy that is why it supports politically democratic system of government to minimize state interference and relieve capitalists from paying taxes and to obtain subsidies from the government on the production of different goods and services.
- Therefore, both need each other for survival.



Islamic stance on democracy

Islam has the same stance on democracy which it has on capitalism. Islam does not recognize free market economy nor promotes fully controlled economy. Islam seeks the socio-economic welfare of individuals as well as state. Similarly, Islam do not recognize popular sovereignty nor monarchism and one man show in politics. Islam promotes the system of government through Mutual consultation or Khilafah in which sovereignty vests in Allah almighty only and Khalifah represents and safeguards the writ of Allah almighty.

(Islam and the Liberal democracy, Journal of Democracy, vol. 07, 1996)



ISLAMIC VIEW.....

- Under the conditions of the contemporary global politics, democracy cannot be considered totally opposite to Islamic Teachings. Although there are several deficiencies that have made this system of government failed to meet the political needs of modern man. In these discussions, Muslim scholars bring historically important concepts from within the Islamic tradition together with the basic concepts of democracy as understood in the Qur'an. The Qur'an lays emphasis on what it calls Shura (Mutual Consultation of Muslims) (Kom, 2016, vol. V (3) : 1–18)

وَشَاوِرْهُمْ فِي الْأَمْرِ فَإِذَا عَزَمْتَ فَتَوَكَّلْ عَلَى اللَّهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ يُحِبُّ الْمُتَوَكِّلِينَ (3:159)

وَأْمُرْهُمْ شُورَىٰ بَيْنَهُمْ (42:38)



Importance of Mutual Consultation

- Even the messenger of Allah was required to consult his people in public matters. So, Muslims should solve their public issues by mutual consultation. It may be possible that mutual consultation in the hierarchy of present democracy may not be the same which is required by the Quran. However, the way of solving issues in the present Western democracy and the Qur'anic required consultation of Muslims may be the similar in spirit. ([American Journal of Islamic Social Sciences](#); Plainfield, Ind. [Vol. 1, Iss. 1](#), (Spring 1984): 11.)



Consultation in Islam cont.....

- The Qur'anic text not only gives us the concept of Shura (consultation) but also do not say to dictatorship or monarchy. There are several precedents of the four right-guided Caliphs that lead us to the idea of solving public matters through mutual consultation.
- The main claim in Islamic democracy is to establish a government based on Islamic values as prescribed by the Quran, Sunnah and traditions of the four right-guided Caliphs. This would happen only when the whole governing body including the Muslim Caliph, Governors and the custodians of all the constituencies of Islamic state are democratic well versed in Islamic traditions and customs. Such democracy which is run such God conscious governing body will be sustainable and useful at large.
(Omar's Methodology in Administration : the Administrative Pillars and Patterns of Administrative Applications in Era of the Caliph Omar Ibn Al-Khattab)

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Main difference between democracy and Islamic system of government

- Democracy believes in popular sovereignty while Islam believes in the sovereignty of Allah
- In democracy the elected representatives may make laws according to their will while in Islamic system of government all the laws will be made compatible with Quran and Sunnah.
- Democracy believes in the welfare of capitalists while Islamic system of government take cares of all the citizens.
- In democracy the members of legislative counsel may not necessarily fulfill the basic qualification of Ijtihad while in Islamic system of government the representatives of Majlis-e-Shora must qualify the characteristics of a Mujtahid. (al- Ahkam al- Sultaniyyah, by Imam Mawardi)



Islam and Secularism

- Secularism discards the influence of religion from public affairs especially public education.
- Separation of state and its constitutional bodies from religious teachings. (*Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* Vol. 6, No. 1 (Spring, 1967), pp. 17-28)
- To secularize means “to make something less religious or keeping away it from being controlled by religious clerics.
- In a secular state there is a separation between state and religion.
- The secular state has no religious foundations or ideology. (Taylor, Charles. "The meaning of secularism." *The Hedgehog Review*, vol. 12, no. 3, 2010, p. 23+. Accessed 12 Jan. 2021.)



Difference between Islam and Secularism

- For Muslims, Islam is more than a set of beliefs or rituals but a code of complete conduct. Muslims believe the supremacy and sovereignty of Allah.

إِن الْحُكْمَ إِلَّا لِلَّهِ أَمَرَ أَلَّا تَعْبُدُوا إِلَّا إِيَّاهُ (12:40)

- In Islamic state, legislation can be done within the limits prescribed by the Quran and Sunnah.

وَمَنْ لَمْ يَحْكَمْ بِمَا أَنزَلَ اللَّهُ فَأُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْكَافِرُونَ (5:44)

Whosoever do not establish and decide by which Allah has revealed are disbelievers.



Historical background

As the science flourished in 20th Century, religion was set aside and given a full authority to rationality. This was the beginning of secularism. Historically speaking, secularism represents the victory, in the sphere of state institutions, and of human knowledge over the revealed knowledge.

(A short history of secularism G Smith - 2007 - Bloomsbury Publishing)



Viewpoints of Islam and Secularism about the creation of Universe

According to Quran and Sunnah the creation of the universe and all that exists is evidence of the best science, the science of the Creator while secularism teaches that this universe is self created under the rule of Natural Selection of Charles Darwin and is running automatically as per role of natural forces. (Charles Darwin On the Origin of Species by Means of Natural Selection (1859)

إِنَّ رَبَّكُمُ اللَّهُ الَّذِي خَلَقَ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ فِي سِتَّةِ أَيَّامٍ ثُمَّ اسْتَوَى عَلَى الْعَرْشِ يُغْشِي اللَّيْلَ النَّهَارَ يَطْلُبُهُ حَثِيثًا وَالشَّمْسُ وَالْقَمَرُ وَالنُّجُومُ مُسَخَّرَاتٌ بِأَمْرِهِ أَلَا لَهُ الْخَلْقُ وَالْأَمْرُ تَبَارَكَ اللَّهُ رَبُّ الْعَالَمِينَ (07:54)

Your guardian-Lord is God Who created the heavens and the earth in six days and is firmly established on the throne (of authority): He draweth the night as a veil O'er the day each seeking the other in rapid succession: He created the sun the moon and the stars (all) governed by laws under His command. Is it not His to create and to govern? Blessed be God the cherisher and sustainer of the worlds!



The first historical denial of the sovereignty of Allah in worldly affairs

- Secularism considers religion as a private matter while politics as public that is why personal discretion should not interfere in public.
- According to this argument politics and religion constitute two different paradigms of reality.
- Accordingly, religion focuses on spirituality while politics on materiality of life of the community. For this reason, religion cannot play any public role in state business. The Quran says:

قَالُوا يَا شُعَيْبُ أَصَلَاتُكَ تَأْمُرُكَ أَنْ نَتْرَكَ مَا يَعْبُدُ آبَاؤُنَا أَوْ أَنْ نَفْعَلَ فِي أَمْوَالِنَا مَا نَشَاءُ إِنَّكَ لَأَنْتَ الْحَلِيمُ الرَّشِيدُ (11:87)

They said : “ Oh Shu’aib ! Does thy (religion of) prayer Command thee that we Leave off the worship which Our fathers practised, or That we leave off doing What we like with our property ? Truly, though art the one That forbearth with faults And is right-minded ! ”



Contradiction between theory and practice

- Hypothetically, secularism asserts that it does not separate citizens from their religion and claim that citizens are free to worship according their choice of religion.
- But in practice it is not true, everywhere we see secular states like India and France are interfering in the religious matters of citizens, especially Muslims.

(https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Secularism_in_France)



What should we do??

Muslims are required to follow the Prophet Muhammad (Peace be upon him) in all public and private matters. So, all the political and private affairs of Muslims are supposed to be treated under the principles of the Quran, Sunnah and the precedents of the four Right Guided Caliphs.

قُلْ أَطِيعُوا اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَإِنْ تَوَلَّوْا فَإِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ الْكَافِرِينَ (03:32)

Say: “Obey God and His Apostle”; but if they turn back God loveth not those who reject Faith.



Islam & Socialism

- Although generally considered to be of European origin, socialism (Arabic الاشتراكية) also has roots in the Arab Middle East. Some of Muslim scholars like Jamal al-Din al-Afghani are of the view that socialism is copying the principles of socio-economics justice into the modern days economics system.

(Islam and Socialism, the Oxford Dictionary of Islam. <http://www.oxfordislamicstudies.com/article/opr/t125/e2233>)

- In 19th century some of the Islamic reformists like Maulana Ubaidullah Sindhi and many others began to articulate socialism as compatible to the socio-economic justice of Islam. These reformers have tried to preach socialistic thoughts in the name of Islamic Socialism. Among the political leaders in Pakistan, Mr. Zulfikar Ali Bhutto was pro socialism.

(Tahir Kamran, *Ubaidullah Sindhi as a Revolutionary: A Study of Socialist Activism in Deobandi Islam* in: Béatrice Hendrich, <https://doi.org/10.5771/9783956504648-151>)



The foundation of socialism

- Materialism is the philosophical foundation of socialism.
- Socialistic system believes only in material reality of socio-economic equality. It denies all kinds of metaphysical realities like God, Angels, Hell and Heaven.
- It attempts to explain every event in the universe as resulting from the cause and effect, and thus denies the existence of Allah.
- Physical phenomena are responsible to run the business of this universe.

وَقَالُوا مَا هِيَ إِلَّا حَيَاتُنَا الدُّنْيَا نَمُوتُ وَنَحْيَا وَمَا يُهْلِكُنَا إِلَّا الدَّهْرُ وَمَا لَهُمْ بِذَلِكَ مِنْ عِلْمٍ إِنْ هُمْ إِلَّا يَظُنُّونَ (45:24)

And they say: "What is there but our life in this world? We shall die and we live, and nothing but time can destroy us." But of that they have no knowledge: they merely conjecture:



Common Points between Socialism and Islamic Socio-economic Justice

1. Prohibition of the accumulation of wealth in the hands of the privileged class of society.
2. Organization of the economic structure of state to ensure socio-economic welfare.
3. Equal opportunities for earning livelihood to all citizens.



Differentiating Points between Socialism and Islamic socio-economic

1. Socialistic system believes only in material reality and denies all kinds of metaphysical realities.
2. Priority of collective social interest over the socio-economic needs of individuals.
3. Preventing the class differences through social revolution by waging socio-economic tug of war between privileged and non privileged classes.
4. No moral, ethical and spiritual approach for the implementation of Socio-economic justice.
5. Socialism is only a socio-economic guidelines while Islam is a complete code of conduct.
6. Islamic Socialism is nothing more than restricting Islam only to socio-economic justice.



Difference between Socialism and Islam

- Islam advocates socio economic equality through socio-economic cooperation and coordination.
- While socialism equates it between the privileged and non privileged through warfare and enmity between rich and poor.
- The basis of social solidarity in the Islamic socialist model is a combination of equality, justice, mutuality, and responsibility.

﴿وَلَا تَتَمَنَّوْا مَا فَضَّلَ اللَّهُ بِهِ بَعْضَكُمْ عَلَى بَعْضٍ لِلرِّجَالِ نَصِيبٌ مِّمَّا اكْتَسَبُوا وَلِلنِّسَاءِ نَصِيبٌ مِّمَّا اكْتَسَبْنَ وَاسْأَلُوا اللَّهَ مِنْ فَضْلِهِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ كَانَ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمًا﴾ (4:32)

Do not covet what Allah has conferred more abundantly on some of you than others. Men shall have a share according to what they have earned, and women shall have a share according to what they have earned. Do ask of Allah His bounty. Allah has full knowledge of everything



Islam & Monarchy

The term kingship or monarchy refers to a relatively complex and hierarchical structure of society in which a central figure—a king or, in certain cases, a queen—undertakes a sovereign role that acts as a value reference for the various groups that constitute the society. Depending on whether this function involves a direct exercise of political power on the part of the person who is discharging it.

(Political Theory of Islam, Maulana Sayyed Abul Ala Maudoodi, Islamic Publication Pvt. Shah Alam Market, Lahore, Pakistan)

It is also possible to govern in an absolute fashion, as a monarch, by holding military office or administering justice without being legitimately entitled to do so through proper voting or mutual consultation as did in Khilafah. In such cases the one who governs does so by relying almost entirely upon force, persecuting public and engendering social cohesion of humans.

الَّذِينَ إِن مَّكَّنَّاهُمْ فِي الْأَرْضِ أَقَامُوا الصَّلَاةَ وَآتَوُا الزَّكَاةَ وَأَمَرُوا بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَنَهَوْا عَنِ الْمُنْكَرِ ۗ وَلِلَّهِ عَاقِبَةُ الْأُمُورِ (22:41)

Allah will certainly help) those who, were We to bestow authority on them in the land, will establish Prayers, render Zakah, enjoin good, and forbid evil. The end of all matters rests with Allah.



Differentiating points between Monarchy and Khilafah

1. Islam recognizes the Khilafah kind of governance only
2. Khalifah leads citizens of Islamic state in all kinds of religious and worldly affairs.
3. Khalifah is instated through proper voting or mutual consultation of qualified Muslims.
4. Khalifah is accountable to Allah and Muslim Public as well.
5. Khalifah does his utmost struggle establish the writ of Allah in the jurisdictions of Islamic state and the world at large.
6. To develop well organized socio-economic Islamic welfare state.
7. Can be impeached through the proper constitutional way.
8. A monarch lacks all the above-mentioned qualifications.

Summary



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In Islam sovereignty vests in Allah almighty alone and mankind enjoys the status of Caliph. In the Islamic mode of governance, Muslims are supposed to follow and obey the Shariah law. The Holy Qur'an obliges Muslims to establish governments on laws given by Allah through His Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) and rule people on the foundations of justice and equity so that people can live happily under the Divine Just rule. Government run on the guidelines given by the four right guided Caliphs are to be followed in dealing all types of public and private matters of Muslim. The holy Qur'an emphasizes on Shura (consultation) . Islam is exclusivist and does not accept secularism and socialism, monarchism, because Islam has the dynamic faculties in guiding its followers towards the worldly and eternal success.



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